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Petrochemical industry officials have said that the extreme pressure exerted on plant managers during the last five years to improve profits by cutting costs has done nothing to impair the industry's ability to operate safely. However, environmentalists contend that the recent rash of serious oil spills and accidents at petrochemical plants is traceable to cost-cutting measures.

Which of the following, if true, would provide the strongest support for the position held by industry officials?

A. The petrochemical industry benefits if accidents do not occur, since accidents involve risk of employee injury as well as loss of equipment and product.

B. Petrochemical industry unions recently demanded that additional money be spent on safety and environmental protection measures, but the unions readily abandoned those demands in exchange for job security.

C. Despite major cutbacks in most other areas of operation, the petrochemical industry has devoted more of its resources to environmental and safety measures in the last five years than in the preceding five years.

D. There is evidence that the most damaging of the recent oil spills would have been prevented had cost-cutting measures not been instituted.

E. Both the large fines and the adverse publicity generated by the most recent oil spill have prompted the petrochemical industry to increase the resources devoted to oil-spill prevention.

Argument Evaluation

Situation Petrochemical industry officials claim that pressure on plant managers to cut costs over the past five years has not made the industry's operations any less safe. Environmentalists claim that recent oil spills and accidents show otherwise.

Reasoning *What evidence would most strongly suggest that the cost-cutting pressure was not responsible for the recent rash of oil spills and accidents?* Evidence that the plant managers did not cut costs in any specific ways likely to have increased the likelihood of oil spills and accidents would support the industry officials' position that the cost-cutting pressure has not made petrochemical operations any less safe.

A. Even if the petrochemical industry has good reasons to try to prevent accidents, the recent rash of serious accidents suggests that it is failing to do so and that the cost-cutting pressure might be responsible.

B. This suggests that the unions, whose members could directly observe the cost-cutting pressure's effects, share the environmentalists' belief that this pressure contributed to the oil spills and accidents. Because the unions abandoned their demands, their concerns probably have not been addressed.

C. **Correct.** This suggests that, as the industry officials claim, the cost-cutting pressure has not in itself reduced the industry's effectiveness at preventing oil spills and accidents. Thus, it suggests that other factors are probably responsible for the recent problems.

D. This clearly suggests that the cost-cutting measures have indeed caused the industry to operate less safely, as the environmentalists claim.

E. Although this suggests that the industry is now trying to address the recent problems, the cost-cutting measures might nonetheless have caused all those problems.

The correct answer is C.

•

A company has developed a new sensing device that, according to the company's claims, detects weak, ultralow-frequency electromagnetic signals associated with a beating heart. These signals, which pass through almost any physical obstruction, are purportedly detected by the device even at significant distances. Therefore, if the company's claims are true, their device will radically improve emergency teams' ability to locate quickly people who are trapped within the wreckage of collapsed buildings.

Which of the following, if true, most strengthens the argument?

A. People trapped within the wreckage of collapsed buildings usually have serious injuries that require prompt medical treatment.

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B. The device gives a distinctive reading when the signals it detects come from human beings rather than from any other living beings.

C. Most people who have survived after being trapped in collapsed buildings were rescued within two hours of the building's collapse.

D. Ultralow-frequency signals are not the only electromagnetic signals that can pass through almost any physical obstruction.

E. Extensive training is required in order to operate the device effectively.

Argument Evaluation

Situation A new sensing device can detect—at significant distances and even behind obstructions such as walls—weak, ultralow-frequency electromagnetic signals that are characteristic of heartbeats. It is predicted, based on this information, that the new device will shorten the time it currently takes to locate people buried under collapsed buildings but still alive.

Reasoning *What new information, if accurate, would provide further evidence that would support the prediction?* The existing evidence fails to tell us whether the new device can distinguish between human heartbeats and heartbeats from other species. If the device does not allow the user to distinguish between the heartbeats of humans and those of animals of other species, then the prediction might not be correct, because if there are any nonhuman animals in the building, emergency teams may believe they have located a trapped human and begin a rescue effort, when in fact they have merely located an animal of some other species. Any new information that implies the device can help the user to discern between signals associated with a human heartbeat and signals associated with the heartbeats of animals of other species will strengthen support for the prediction.

A. This implies that prompt rescue of people trapped under collapsed buildings is vitally important. The prediction is that the new device will speed rescue of such people, but the new information here does nothing to indicate that the prediction is accurate.

B. **Correct.** As explained in the Reasoning section above, there is a crucial gap in the argument: The argument does not indicate whether the device allows the user to distinguish between signals associated with human heartbeats and signals associated with the heartbeats of other species. This information fills that gap.

C. Even if this is true, shortening the time for locating and rescuing people from collapsed buildings would clearly be beneficial. However, the new information given here does not make it more likely that the prediction is correct.

D. If this is correct, then, if anything, it somewhat undermines the evidence given for the prediction, since it raises the possibility that the detection ability of the device might be impeded by "noise" from irrelevant electromagnetic signals near the collapsed building.

E. This could lead to practical obstacles when using the device even in emergency situations, with the result that the device might never actually be used by competent personnel to "improve emergency teams' ability" because the "extensive training" would cost too much.

The correct answer is B.

•

Economist: The price of tap water in our region should be raised drastically. **Supplies in local freshwater reservoirs have been declining for years** because water is being used faster than it can be replenished. Since the price of tap water has been low, **few users have bothered to adopt even easy conservation measures.**

The two sections in **boldface** play which of the following roles in the economist's argument?

A. The first is a conclusion for which support is provided, and which in turn supports the main conclusion; the second is the main conclusion.

B. The first is an observation for which the second provides an explanation; the second is the main conclusion but not the only conclusion.

C. The first is a premise supporting the argument's main conclusion; so is the second.

D. The first is the only conclusion; the second provides an explanation for the first.

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D. The first is the only conclusion; the second provides an explanation for the first.

E. The first is the main conclusion; the second is a conclusion for which support is provided, and which in turn supports the first.

Argument Construction

Situation Local water supplies have been declining for years because of excessive water use and low prices. Few users have adopted even easy conservation measures.

Reasoning *What roles do the two **boldfaced** statements play in the argument?* Both are factual observations. Since no further evidence or support is provided for either, neither can be a conclusion in the argument. However, interconnected causal explanations, signaled by *because* and *since*, are provided for both. The observation in the first **boldfaced** statement is causally explained by the further observation that water is being used faster than it can be replenished, which in turn is causally explained by the entire final sentence. The observation in the second **boldfaced** statement is causally explained by the observation that the price of tap water has been low. The only remaining portion of the argument is the initial sentence, a recommendation supported by these four observations together, and by the causal claims in which they are embedded. Thus, the four observations (including the two **boldfaced** statements) and the causal claims containing them are all premises, and the initial statement is the argument's only conclusion.

A. As explained in the Reasoning section above, the two **boldfaced** statements are premises of the argument. Although causal explanations are provided for both, no support or evidence is provided for either. Neither statement is inferred from anything else in the argument, so neither can be a conclusion in the argument.

B. As explained in the Reasoning section above, the second **boldfaced** statement does provide part of the causal explanation for the observation in the first **boldfaced** statement. But the second is not a conclusion. It is not inferred from anything else in the argument, so it cannot be a conclusion in the argument.

C. **Correct.** As explained in the Reasoning section above, each of the statements is a premise that serves along with other claims to support the recommendation in the initial sentence, which is the argument's only conclusion, and in that sense its main conclusion.

D. As explained in the Reasoning section above, the second **boldfaced** statement does provide part of the causal explanation for the observation in the first **boldfaced** statement. But the first is not a conclusion. It is not inferred from anything else in the argument, so it cannot be a conclusion in the argument.

E. As explained in the Reasoning section above, the two **boldfaced** statements are premises of the argument. Although causal explanations are provided for both, no support or evidence is provided for either. Neither statement is inferred from anything else in the argument, so neither can be a conclusion in the argument.

The correct answer is C.

•

Maize contains the vitamin niacin, but not in a form the body can absorb. Pellagra is a disease that results from niacin deficiency. When maize was introduced into southern Europe from the Americas in the eighteenth century, it quickly became a dietary staple, and many Europeans who came to subsist primarily on maize developed pellagra. Pellagra was virtually unknown at that time in the Americas, however, even among people who subsisted primarily on maize.

Which of the following, if true, most helps to explain the contrasting incidence of pellagra described above?

A. Once introduced into southern Europe, maize became popular with landowners because of its high yields relative to other cereal crops.

B. Maize grown in the Americas contained more niacin than maize grown in Europe did.

C. Traditional ways of preparing maize in the Americas convert maize's niacin into a nutritionally useful form.

D. In southern Europe, many of the people who consumed maize also ate niacin-rich foods.

E. Before the discovery of pellagra's link with niacin, it was widely believed the disease was an infection that could be transmitted from person to person.

Argument Construction

Situation Maize contains niacin in a form the body cannot readily utilize, and pellagra is a disease that results

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Situation Maize contains niacin in a form the body cannot readily utilize, and pellagra is a disease that results from niacin deficiency. In southern Europe a diet heavily dependent on maize resulted in a high incidence of pellagra, whereas in the Americas a diet similarly dependent on maize had no such effect.

Reasoning *What would account for the differing effects of a maize-dependent diet in Europe versus the Americas?* A diet primarily consisting of maize resulted in widespread niacin deficiency, and consequent pellagra, in southern Europe, where maize was introduced, but had no such effect in the Americas, where that diet was traditional. Identifying a factor that would account for why people in the Americas were getting more niacin from the same staple food would explain that discrepancy.

A. An explanation for why maize became popular does nothing to explain the differing effects of a maize-dependent diet in Europe as opposed to the Americas.

B. Because the passage specifies the niacin in maize is not accessible to the body, higher levels of niacin would still be inaccessible and therefore would not explain the differing incidence of pellagra in the Americas versus Europe.

C. **Correct.** If methods of preparing maize in the Americas converted maize's niacin into a form the body can absorb and European cooking techniques did not, that would explain the differing incidence of a disease caused by niacin deficiency in the two regions.

D. Consumption of niacin-rich foods in southern Europe would be expected to lower the incidence of pellagra in the region and therefore would not explain why that incidence was higher there.

E. Mistaken beliefs about the causes of pellagra do nothing to explain its relative frequency in Europe versus the Americas.

The correct answer is C.

•

Mayor: False alarms from home security systems waste so much valuable police time that in many communities, police have stopped responding to alarms from homes whose systems frequently produce false alarms. This policy reduces wastage of police time but results in a loss of protection for some residents. To achieve a comparable reduction in wastage without reducing protection for residents, the council has enacted a measure to fine residents for repeated false alarms.

Which of the following, if true, casts the most doubt on whether the measure enacted by the council will achieve its goal?

A. A fine in the amount planned by the council will not cover the expenses police typically incur when they respond to a false alarm.

B. Homes equipped with security systems are far less likely to be broken into than are homes without security systems.

C. The threat of fines is likely to cause many residents to deactivate their security systems.

D. The number of home security systems is likely to increase dramatically over the next five years.

E. Many home security systems have never produced false alarms.

Evaluation of a Plan

Situation In many communities, police have been responding to false home-security alarms but have ceased to respond to alarms from homes that often have such false alarms. To reduce wastage of police time without compromising residents' home protection, one town council has enacted a new measure that will fine home residents for repeated false alarms.

Reasoning *What fact or occurrence would most reduce the likelihood that the town council's newly enacted measure would achieve its goal, which is to reduce wastage of police time without compromising home protection?* Note that the goal is not to eliminate all wastage of police time or to pay all the costs of it; some random wastage is to be expected. But if many residents deactivated their security alarms (even well-functioning systems) because they wish to avoid being fined, this could reduce the level of home protection for those residents.

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A. The goal is to reduce wastage of police time resulting from false security-system alarms, not necessarily to cover all the costs in police time for such alarms.

B. This seems obviously true, but it is also irrelevant to the frequency of false home-security alarms. It is therefore irrelevant, also, to whether the council's measure will effectively address wastage of police time stemming from such alarms.

C. **Correct.** If this occurred, it would result in a lower level of home protection for some residents and would mean that the town council's measure would have failed to achieve its goal.

D. This scenario does not make the council's measure more likely to fail to achieve its goal. If the increase in alarm systems occurs, it will likely result in more protection for the homes of more residents. Assuming vigorous enforcement of the new measure, we have no reason to believe that the number of false alarms would increase.

E. This has little bearing on the likelihood of the council's measure succeeding. Any home security system that has never produced a false alarm could do so tomorrow, for all kinds of reasons.

The correct answer is C.

•

Excavation of the house of a third-century Camarnian official revealed that he had served four magistrates—public officials who administer the law—over his thirty-year public career, in four provincial capital cities. However, given the Camarnian administrative system of that era, it is unclear whether he served them simultaneously, as a traveling administrator living for part of the year in each provincial capital, or else did so sequentially, leaving one magistrate after several years to join another.

Which of the following would, if found in the excavation, most likely help reveal the pattern of the official's administrative service?

A. Maps and documents describing each of the four provincial capitals

B. A cache of the official's documents related to work from early in his career

C. A set of cups of a type made only in the city of the first magistrate whom the official is known to have served

D. Several pieces of furniture in the styles of two of the provincial capital cities

E. Heavy clothing appropriate only for the coldest of the four cities

Argument Construction

Situation Evidence from an excavation makes clear that a particular third-century Camarnian official served four magistrates in four provincial capitals over his thirty-year career, but it is unclear whether he served the magistrates simultaneously or sequentially.

Reasoning *What evidence, if it were also found in the excavation, would be most helpful in determining whether the official served the magistrates simultaneously or sequentially?* It would be helpful to find documents from throughout the magistrate's career indicating at what times he worked for each magistrate, or even documents from just one period, as long as there were a large number, because this would likely show whether he was working for just one magistrate or for all four.

A. We already know that the official worked in each of the four capitals. The fact that maps and documents describing the capitals were at his house tells us nothing about whether he worked for magistrates in these capitals simultaneously or not.

B. **Correct.** Presumably, the work-related documents would show whom he was working for at the time, and for how long—and would provide evidence as to whether he was working for multiple magistrates or for just one.

C. Merely finding a set of cups made only in one of the cities tells us little. Even if we knew when he acquired the set, he need not have been working for the magistrate of that city at the time he acquired it; perhaps he had simply traveled to that city.

D. One frequently moves furniture when moving from one city to another, so the fact that the official had pieces of furniture that may have come from different cities does not give us any indication of whether the official worked for all four magistrates simultaneously or not.

E. The fact that heavy clothing appropriate only for the coldest of the four cities was found in the excavation of the

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E. The fact that heavy clothing appropriate only for the coldest of the four cities was found in the excavation of the official's house does not imply that other clothing, appropriate for one or more of the other cities, was not found. Consistent with the finding of the heavy clothing, the official may have worked exclusively in the city for which that clothing was appropriate, or worked intermittently in this city.

The correct answer is B.

•

In 1563, in Florence's Palazzo Vecchio, Giorgio Vasari built in front of an existing wall a new wall on which he painted a mural. Investigators recently discovered a gap between Vasari's wall and the original, large enough to have preserved anything painted on the original. Historians believe that Leonardo da Vinci had painted, but left unfinished, a mural on the original wall; some historians had also believed that by 1563, the mural had been destroyed. However, it is known that in the late 1560s, when renovating another building, Santa Maria Novella, Vasari built a façade over its frescoes, and the frescoes were thereby preserved. Thus, Leonardo's Palazzo Vecchio mural probably still exists behind Vasari's wall.

Which of the following is an assumption on which the argument depends?

A. Leonardo rarely if ever destroyed artworks that he left unfinished.

B. Vasari was likely unaware that the mural in the Palazzo Vecchio had willingly been abandoned by Leonardo.

C. Vasari probably would not have built the Palazzo Vecchio wall with a gap behind it except to preserve something behind the new wall.

D. Leonardo would probably have completed the Palazzo Vecchio mural if he had had the opportunity to do so.

E. When Vasari preserved the frescoes of Santa Maria Novella he did so secretly.

Argument Construction

Situation Georgio Vasari built a new wall in front of an existing wall in the Palazzo Vecchio that historians believe had had an unfinished mural by Leonardo da Vinci painted on it. Some historians, however, believe the mural had been destroyed by the time Vasari built the new wall. There is a gap between the old and new wall, large enough to have preserved anything painted on it, as there is in Santa Maria Novella, where Vasari also constructed a new wall in front of an old wall; on that wall, the building's frescoes were preserved.

Reasoning *What claim needs to be true for the cited facts to support the conclusion that Leonardo's Palazzo Vecchio mural likely still exists behind Vasari's wall?* If there are other equally likely reasons that Vasari would have left a gap between the old wall and a new wall, besides preserving any painting on the old wall, the stated facts would not support the conclusion. After all, it may be only fortuitous that the frescoes in the Santa Maria Novella were preserved when Vasari built the new wall with a gap between it and the old wall. Therefore, the argument depends on assuming that it is unlikely that Vasari would have created a gap between the old and new walls unless he had been trying to preserve something painted on the old wall.

A. The argument does not depend on the claim that Leonardo rarely if ever destroyed his unfinished artworks. Obviously, it does depend on the claim that he did not always do so, but even if he fairly regularly destroyed unfinished artworks, this mural could be one of the ones he did not—perhaps the reason the mural was left unfinished was that he died before completing it.

B. The argument does not depend on Vasari knowing that Leonardo had willingly abandoned the mural. Even if Leonardo did willingly leave it unfinished, Vasari could nonetheless have thought the mural was of value and wanted to preserve it.

C. **Correct.** If there had been other likely reasons for Vasari to have built a gap behind the new wall other than to preserve something painted on the old wall, the cited facts would not be a good reason to believe that Vasari built the gap for the purpose of preserving anything painted on it.

D. Leonardo may have had no interest in finishing the mural. Vasari could nevertheless have thought that there was value in preserving it.

E. There is no need to assume that Vasari preserved the frescoes at Santa Maria Novella secretly. Even if he did not do so in this instance, he could have preserved other paintings secretly by the same means, or he may have let others know that he was preserving Leonardo's mural, although there is no historical record that he did let them

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others know that he was preserving Leonardo's mural, although there is no historical record that he did let them know.

The correct answer is C.

•

Coffee shop owner: A large number of customers will pay at least the fair market value for a cup of coffee, even if there is no formal charge. Some will pay more than this out of appreciation of the trust that is placed in them. And our total number of customers is likely to increase. We could therefore improve our net cash flow by implementing an honor system in which customers pay what they wish for coffee by depositing money in a can.

Manager: We're likely to lose money on this plan. Many customers would cheat the system, paying a very small sum or nothing at all.

Which of the following, if true, would best support the owner's plan, in light of the manager's concern?

A. The new system, if implemented, would increase the number of customers.

B. By roasting its own coffee, the shop has managed to reduce the difficulties (and cost) of maintaining an inventory of freshly roasted coffee.

C. Many customers stay in the cafe for long stretches of time.

D. The shop makes a substantial profit from pastries and other food bought by the coffee drinkers.

E. No other coffee shop in the area has such a system.

Evaluation of a Plan

Situation The owner and the manager of a coffee shop disagree about whether allowing customers to pay for coffee on an honor system would increase or decrease profits.

Reasoning *What would be the best evidence that the honor-system plan would increase profits even if many customers cheated the system?* The owner argues that profits would increase because many customers will choose to pay as much or more than before and the total number of customers will likely increase. But the manager points out that many customers would also choose to pay little or nothing. Assuming that the manager is correct about that, what further support could the owner present for the claim that the plan would still be profitable?

A. Since the owner has already basically asserted this, asserting it again would not provide any significant additional support for the plan.

B. This suggests that the shop is already profitable, not that the honor-system plan would make it more profitable.

C. Customers who stay in the cafe for long stretches would not necessarily pay any more per cup on the honor-system plan than other customers would.

D. **Correct.** If the customer base increases (as both the owner and the manager seem to agree), more customers will likely purchase highly profitable pastries and other foods, thus boosting profits.

E. The reason no other coffee shop in the area has an honor system may be that their owners and managers have determined that it would not be profitable.

The correct answer is D.

•

Birds have been said to be descended from certain birdlike dinosaur species with which they share distinctive structural features. The fossil record, however, shows that this cannot be so, since there are bird fossils that are much older than the earliest birdlike dinosaur fossils that have been found.

Which of the following is an assumption on which the argument relies?

A. The birdlike dinosaurs have no living descendants.

B. There are no flightless dinosaur species that have the distinctive structural features shared by birds and birdlike dinosaurs.

C. There are no birdlike dinosaur fossils that are older than the bird fossils but have not yet been unearthed.

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D. It could not have been the case that some birds were descended from one of the birdlike dinosaur species and other birds from another.

E. Birds cannot have been descended from dinosaur species with which the birds do not share the distinctive structural features.

Argument Construction

Situation Although birds have been said to be descended from birdlike dinosaurs, some bird fossils predate the earliest known birdlike dinosaur fossils.

Reasoning *What must be true in order for the premise that some bird fossils predate the earliest known birdlike dinosaur fossils to support the conclusion that birds are not descended from birdlike dinosaurs?* The argument implicitly reasons that since the cited bird fossils predate the earliest known birdlike dinosaur fossils, they must be from birds that lived before the earliest birdlike dinosaurs, and which therefore could not have been descended from birdlike dinosaurs. This reasoning assumes that any birdlike dinosaurs that lived before the first birds would have left fossils that still exist. It also assumes that no undiscovered birdlike dinosaur fossils predate the cited bird fossils.

A. The argument is only about whether birds are descended from birdlike dinosaurs. Whether birdlike dinosaurs have any living descendants other than birds is irrelevant.

B. The argument is only about birds and birdlike dinosaurs. It is not about other types of dinosaurs that were not birdlike.

C. **Correct.** If any undiscovered birdlike dinosaur fossils predate the cited bird fossils, then the latter fossils' age does not support the conclusion that birds are not descended from birdlike dinosaurs.

D. The argument purports to establish that the relative ages of bird fossils and birdlike dinosaur fossils show that birds cannot be descended from any of the known birdlike dinosaur species. In doing this, it acknowledges multiple birdlike dinosaur species and leaves open the question of whether some birds may be descended from one such species and other birds from another such species.

E. The argument does not claim that the known fossil record shows that birds cannot be descended from dinosaurs. It only claims that the record shows that they cannot be descended from the birdlike dinosaurs that shared their distinctive structural features.

The correct answer is C.

•

The total market value of real estate in Altonville has steadily declined over the past four years. This decline has meant the overall figure on which the city's property tax is based—the assessed value of that real estate—has also declined. Moreover, the percentage of assessed value that was paid as property taxes to the city did not change during this period.

The information above most strongly supports which of the following?

A. Money collected from property taxes provided most of Altonville's revenue during the past four years.

B. The percentage of Altonville's overall revenue that was collected from property taxes did not change over the past four years.

C. Altonville officials had proposed raising property tax rates during the past four years but never did so because of strong opposition from property owners.

D. The total amount of revenue that Altonville has collected from property taxes has declined over the past four years.

E. During the past four years, Altonville officials also did not increase tax rates on other sources of revenue such as retail sales or business profits.

Argument Construction

Situation Altonville's real estate has declined in value in recent years, and therefore the total value of the property on which the city can charge property taxes is also reduced. The percentage of assessed value charged as property tax has remained constant.

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charged as property tax has remained constant.

Reasoning *What would follow from the facts presented?* A constant percentage of a total that is decreasing would likewise decrease—for example, 10 percent of eighty is less than 10 percent of one hundred. Therefore, the information supports the conclusion that Altonville's total revenue from property taxes has fallen over the period specified.

A. The passage suggests nothing about property taxes relative to other sources of revenue.

B. The passage does not suggest property taxes are unchanged as a share of Altonville's total revenue.

C. There is no mention of any proposal to raise property tax rates.

D. **Correct.** The passage states total property values have fallen while the percentage of that value levied as tax is constant. Therefore, the information supports the conclusion that revenues from property tax have fallen in tandem with the declining value of property in the city.

E. The passage implies nothing about whether taxes other than property taxes have increased.

The correct answer is D.

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